

GOING BEYOND IN COVENANT RELATIONSHIPS

INTRO: Covenant (Holman Bible Dictionary): A pact, treaty, alliance or agreement between two parties.

- Pact = An agreement. Harmony of opinion.
- Treaty = A formal agreement for peace, military alliance or commerce.

**(ILLUSTRATE HOW COVENANTS
WERE CONSUMATED IN OLD
TESTAMENT TIMES)**

When we are in covenant with God and with one another in the body of Christ, it means that we have made a formal commitment to work in harmony to advance common interests. It means that we have given our personal guarantee to carry out explicit responsibilities.

Our God is a covenant-maker:

- He made a covenant with Noah to never again destroy the earth with a flood and set as His sign the rainbow... (Genesis 9:8)
- He made a covenant with Abraham to give the Promised Land to Abraham's descendants... (Genesis 15:18)
- He made a covenant with Israel's King David to establish His throne forever... (2 Samuel 7:8-17)
- He affirmed that covenant with David's son, King Solomon... (1 Kings 9:1-9)
- He declared He would keep His covenants for a thousand generations... (Deuteronomy 7:9)

These are only a few examples of the many covenants of God with individuals and nations, recorded in the pages of Holy Scripture. They had certain things in common:

- God initiated them... This is of great encouragement to me because it demonstrates His forethought, His love and His desire to bless His people and manifest His will for them.
- In each, God committed Himself to take certain actions and called upon the other party to walk in humility, faith and obedience...

We have been called by our Lord Jesus Christ to come into covenant with Him and one another on many different levels.

Our spiritual life is like the shape of a cross. It extends vertically, up and down, between God and us, but it also extends horizontally, from left to right, with one another.

Over the next few weeks we are going to talk about coming into covenant with our brothers and sisters in four different areas:

- Covenant to love each other...

- Covenant to attend church and a life group faithfully...
- Covenant to create a culture of invitation... Become a body of bringers.
- Covenant to support the work of God through our financial resources...

COVENANT LOVE

John 15:9-17 (NKJV) *“As the Father loved Me, I also have loved you; abide in My love. 10 If you keep My commandments, you will abide in My love, just as I have kept My Father’s commandments and abide in His love. 11 “These things I have spoken to you, that My joy may remain in you, and that your joy may be full. 12 This is My commandment, that you love one another as I have loved you. 13 Greater love has no one than this, than to lay down one’s life for his friends. 14 You are My friends if you do whatever I command you. 15 No longer do I call you servants, for a servant does not know what his master is*

doing; but I have called you friends, for all things that I heard from My Father I have made known to you. 16 You did not choose Me, but I chose you and appointed you that you should go and bear fruit, and that your fruit should remain, that whatever you ask the Father in My name He may give you. 17 These things I command you, that you love one another.” This indicates that we are to come into a covenant relationship with each other and commit ourselves to loving one another despite the pressure to do otherwise.

If we truly love God, then we will love others. 1 John 4:20 *“If someone says, “I love God,” and hates his brother, he is a liar; for he who does not love his brother whom he has seen, how can he love God whom he has not seen?”*

Jesus gives us in John 15 His commandment that we love one another. This is a direct order from Christ. It is not a suggestion.

There are two Greek words that alternate for our English word “love” in John 15:

- Agape or benevolent love... When Jesus says keeping His commandments results in abiding in His love it is “agape” – that is, benevolent love. It is love that gives what the other needs. Jesus uses “agape” when He says ***“Greater love has no one than this, than to lay down one’s life for His friends.”*** Agape is the giving kind of love.
- Agapao love, or a choice of the will... Jesus uses the word “agapao” in describing the love of the Father towards Him, and the love that He calls us to show one another.

What we are saying is that the covenantal love that Jesus calls us to is not based on

carnal feelings, desires, or selfish motives. It is a matter of the will born of benevolent hearts:

- We love because we are Christians...
Period.
- We love because He first love us...
Period.
- We love because the Spirit of love indwells us... Period.

If we choose to come into a covenant love relationship with our brothers and sisters, what does that look like? Jesus says we are to love “*as He loved us.*” Wow! Behold what manner of love is this?

- It is a love that takes the first step...
- It is a love that initiates from the lover and is not based on the worth of the lovee...
- It is a love that is benevolent – it looks for ways to add to and benefit the other...

- It is a love that seeks a way and place to serve...
- It is a love that is self-sacrificing...
- It is love that abides and is enduring...

Feelings come and go. Godly love remains! It remains because it is based on character and choice, and not feelings and self-centeredness.

IF WE OBEY HIS COMMAND TO LOVE, WE WILL ABIDE IN HIS LOVE

To abide means to remain, to have a home, to have permanence.

IF WE OBEY HIS COMMAND TO LOVE, HIS JOY REMAINS IN US

Our English word “happy” derives from the Old English word, “hap,” which has to do with possessing pleasant circumstances.

The joy of the Lord is something completely different. It’s not based on circumstances —

it is based on abiding in Him. It surpasses all human understanding because it is literally out of this world!

IF WE OBEY HIS COMMAND TO LOVE, HE COUNTS US AS HIS FRIENDS

To have a friend is to have a confidant. A friend is one that you:

- Share secrets with...
- Share feelings with...
- Share material possessions with...

Obedience to love one another results in a friendship with God! It results in a special communion in which revelation and thought sharing reach ever increasing heights.

IF WE OBEY HIS COMMAND TO LOVE, WE WILL BEAR EVERLASTING FRUIT

When we love as Jesus commands, it results in words and deeds that please Him. That

fruit will remain. It will go before us to the Judgment Seat of Christ. It will ensure that we experience an abundant entrance into His glorious kingdom.

IF WE OBEY HIS COMMAND TO LOVE, WE WILL PREVAIL IN PRAYER

What a powerful and glorious promise of Jesus! Without Him we can do nothing:

- He is the breath in our lungs...
- He is the guardian of our mind...
- He is the Shepherd of our way...
- He is the rewarder of our labor...

Through prayer we:

- Ascertain His heart...
- Obtain His promises...
- Release His will...

To prevail in prayer is to prevail in every area of life, work and ministry. Our prayers will be much more effective if we walk in

covenant love with God and our brothers and sisters in the Lord.

CONCLUSION:

Repeat with me the covenant we are entering into today with one another:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- I will delight in you...
- I will speak well of you...
- I will protect you...
- I will speak well of you...
- I will love you as I love myself...
- I will speak well of you...
- My stuff is your stuff...
- I will speak well of you...
- I will fight for you...
- I will speak well of you...
- I will weep with you...
- I will speak well of you...
- I will celebrate your victories – Not fear them...
- I will speak well of you...

- I will bless your offspring...
- I will speak well of you...

FACILITATORS QUESTIONS:

- What is covenant? (*It is a binding agreement made between two or more individuals*)
- How long does the Bible say God will keep a covenant? (*One thousand generations*)
- What are the two kinds of love mentioned in John 15? (*Agape love and Agapao love*)
- What does agape love mean? (*It is benevolent love – It is a love that intentionally gives what the other needs*)
- What does agapao love mean? (*It is a intentional choice of the will to love*)
- How should we love each other? (*With agape and agapao love – Discuss how this might look played out in the context of the church*)

- What things are we told we can expect from the Lord when we love him and others as we should? (*Abide in His love – Be filled with joy – Be counted as His friend – Bear eternal fruit – Pray prayers that prevail*)

COVENANT ATTENDANCE

(My history) In 57 years of living on this earth there has never been a time when I was not "In Church":

- I was raised in a church!
- I was dedicated to the Lord in a church!
- I was saved in a church!
- I was baptized in water in a church!
- I was received into membership in a church!
- Susan and I were married in a church!
- We dedicated our children in a church!
- We have raised our family in a church!
- My funeral will be held in a church!

I am literally a product of the church.

Because I am a product of the church, I am a champion of the church. I would fight hell with a water pistol in defense of the church!

I know there are some stinkers (Hypocrites) in the church but Noah had a couple of stinkers (Skunks) on his boat as well, but it was the best thing afloat!

Think of this:

- Jesus went to church. Luke 4:16 (NKJV) *"So He came to Nazareth, where He had been brought up. And as His custom was, He went into the synagogue on the Sabbath day..."*
- The Apostles went to church. Acts 3:1 (NKJV) *"Now Peter and John went up together to the temple at the hour of prayer..."*
- The Apostles attended life groups... Acts 2:46 (NKJV) *"So continuing daily with one accord in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they ate their food with gladness and simplicity of heart..."*

- We are commanded to go to church.
Hebrews 10:25 (NKJV) *"Not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as is the manner of some, but exhorting one another, and so much the more as you see the Day approaching."*

FAITHFULLY ATTENDING CHURCH AND A LIFE GROUP GIVES US AN OPPORTUNITY TO BE FED SPIRITUALLY

People have various opinions of what the responsibilities of the Pastor should be but the Word of God makes it clear that his primary responsibility is:

- To feed the people spiritually... John 21:15-17 (NKJV) *"So when they had eaten breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me more than these?" He said to Him, "Yes, Lord; You know that I love You." He said to him, "Feed My lambs." 16 He said to him again a*

second time, “Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?” He said to Him, “Yes, Lord; You know that I love You.” He said to him, “Tend My sheep.” 17 He said to him the third time, “Simon, son of Jonah, do you love Me?” Peter was grieved because He said to him the third time, “Do you love Me?” And he said to Him, “Lord, You know all things; You know that I love You.” Jesus said to him, “Feed My sheep.”

- To preach and teach the Word of God...
Acts 6:2-4 (NKJV) *"Then the twelve summoned the multitude of the disciples and said, “It is not desirable that we should leave the word of God and serve tables. 3 “Therefore, brethren, seek out from among you seven men of good reputation, full of the Holy Spirit and wisdom, whom we may appoint over this business; 4 “but we will give ourselves continually to prayer and to the ministry of the word.”*

- To equip God's people for works of ministry... Ephesians 4:11-13 (NKJV)
"And He Himself gave some to be apostles, some prophets, some evangelists, and some pastors and teachers, 12 for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry, for the edifying of the body of Christ, 13 till we all come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ."

If we are a faithful church attendee and the pastor and life group leaders discharge their responsibilities, they will not only preach to us but teach us line upon line, precept upon precept, all the while building us up in our most holy faith. The first step to living a successful Christian life is to attend church and a life group faithfully.

Are you ready to covenant with your brothers and sisters to faithfully attend church and a life group in 2017?

FAITHFULLY ATTENDING CHURCH AND A LIFE GROUP GIVES US THE OPPORTUNITY TO FUNCTION AS A BODY

When we connect ourselves, as we should to a local church it helps us realize we are a part of something bigger than ourselves.

Being connected to a local church aids us in our attempt to understand what it means to be a part of the corporate and triumphant church. Matthew 16:18 (NKJV) *“And I also say to you that you are Peter, and on this rock I will build My church, and the gates of Hades shall not prevail against it.”*

When we are a faithful part of the local church and become part of a life group, we become aware of the importance of every other member of the local church. 1

Corinthians 12:18-20, 27 (NKJV) *"But now God has set the members, each one of them, in the body just as He pleased. 19 And if they were all one member, where would the body be? 20 But now indeed there are many members, yet one body. 27 Now you are the body of Christ, and members individually."* Every member of the body is vitally important.

Are you ready to covenant with your brothers and sisters to faithfully attend church and a life group in 2017?

FAITHFULLY ATTENDING CHURCH AND A LIFE GROUP GIVES US THE OPPORTUNITY TO DEVELOP OUR GIFTS

Every believer has natural gifts and abilities that they were born with. The reason we were born with these abilities is because they will fold perfectly into the spiritual

gifts God will give us as we attempt to fulfill His purpose for our lives.

The best place on the planet for developing our gifts is the local church. Think of all the movie stars and recording artists that got their start in the church:

- Elvis Presley...
- Dolly Parton...
- The Gatlin Brothers...
- Charlie Daniels...
- Kanye (Con-yea) West...
- Jessica and Ashley Simpson (Their dad was a preacher)...

I would be afraid to develop my gifts in the church and then use them in the world.

The development of our gifts is the process of walking out our destiny. We are following HIM one step at a time as HE develops us; moves us closer to our destiny; and then takes us to the next level of

development which was no doubt His original intention. 2 Peter 3:18 (NKJV)
"Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ..."

Where can you grow in your faith most effectively? In a church that offers life groups!

Are you ready to covenant with your brothers and sisters to faithfully attend church and a life group in 2017?

FAITHFULLY ATTENDING CHURCH AND A LIFE GROUP GIVES US THE OPPORTUNITY TO MINISTER TO OTHERS

No person is an island to themselves. We all need to serve others but we all need to be served by others as well. Believers who attempt to live their lives solo miss the blessing of serving and being served.

ILLUSTRATION:

A member of a certain church, who previously had been attending services regularly, suddenly stopped coming to church. After a few weeks, the Pastor decided to visit.

The Pastor found the man at home alone, sitting before a blazing fire. Guessing the reason for his Pastor's visit, the man welcomed him, led him to a comfortable chair near the fireplace and waited. The pastor made himself at home but said nothing. In the grave silence, he contemplated the dance of the flames around the burning logs.

After some minutes, the Pastor took the fire tongs, carefully picked up a brightly burning ember and placed it to one side of the hearth all alone. Then he sat back in his chair, still silent. The host watched all this in quiet contemplation. As the one lone ember's

flame flickered and diminished, there was a momentary glow and then its fire was no more. Soon it was cold and lifeless. The Pastor glanced at his watch and realized it was time to leave; he slowly stood up, picked up the cold, dead ember and placed it back in the middle of the fire. Immediately it began to glow, once more with the light and warmth of the burning coals around it. As the Pastor reached the door to leave, his host said with a tear running down his cheek, "Thank you so much for your visit and especially for the fiery sermon. I will be back in church next Sunday."

God ordained the church and fellowship with other believers for the purpose of ministering to the saints and reaching the world. We cannot very well reach the world if we are not receiving ministry from others.

What better place to receive ministry than the local church and a life group?

Take a moment to think about what kind of a Christian we would be if the following were not available to us:

- No other Christians to fellowship (Life group) with...
- No teachers to teach us...
- No discipleship to train us...
- No Pastor to shepherd us; counsel us; marry us; or bury us...
- No life group to do life with...

CONCLUSION:

I want to close with this question: “*What kind of church would this church be, if every member were just like me?*”

Can we commit ourselves today to making this a much better church by covenanting with each other before God to be faithful with our attendance to church and a life group?

CONCLUSION:

The first step of living a successful Christian life is to connect oneself to a church and a life group and then attend faithfully.

I want you to turn to your neighbor and repeat the following covenant after me:

- My pastor expects me to attend church services and my life group faithfully...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church services and my life group faithfully...
- My Christian duty to you and my brothers and sisters in the Lord demands that I attend church services and my life group faithfully...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church and my life group faithfully...
- I believe God's Word commands me to attend church and my life group faithfully...

- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church and my life group faithfully...
- I will no longer allow distractions to keep me away from church services and my life group...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church services and my life group faithfully...
- I will no longer allow excuses to cause me to absent myself from church services and my life group...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church services and my life group faithfully...
- I commit to you that you can expect me to be present at church services and my life group unless I am working on my job or too ill to attend...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to attend church services and my life group faithfully...

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- Who is over all local churches? (*God and the pastor*)
- Who is the human authority in the local church? (*The Pastor*)
- Should one commit to a local church, or is it acceptable to attend more than one church at a time? (*Commitment to one local church is the healthy model – It is difficult to serve if you are not committed to one local church - It is difficult to be accountable if you are bouncing between churches*)
- What would be a suitable reason for being absent from church or life group? (*Work – vacation – sickness*)
- Is it ever appropriate for a Christian to be intentionally absent from church or life group for an extended period of time? (*No*)
- What factors should a person consider when attempting to find a good local church to attend? (*A pastor who*

*preaches the Word – A church that can
minister to the entire family – A church
that provides an opportunity to develop
relationship with other believers)*

COVENANT BRINGING

Mark 2:1-12 (KJV) *“And again he entered into Capernaum after some days; and it was noised that he was in the house. 2 And straightway many were gathered together, insomuch that there was no room to receive them, no, not so much as about the door: and he preached the word unto them. 3 And they come unto him, bringing one sick of the palsy, which was borne of four. 4 And when they could not come nigh unto him for the press, they uncovered the roof where he was: and when they had broken it up, they let down the bed wherein the sick of the palsy lay. 5 When Jesus saw their faith, he said unto the sick of the palsy, Son, thy sins be forgiven thee. 6 But there was certain of the scribes sitting there, and reasoning in their hearts, 7 Why doth this man thus speak blasphemies? who can*

forgive sins but God only? 8 And immediately when Jesus perceived in his spirit that they so reasoned within themselves, he said unto them, Why reason ye these things in your hearts? 9 Whether is it easier to say to the sick of the palsy, Thy sins be forgiven thee; or to say, Arise, and take up thy bed, and walk? 10 But that ye may know that the Son of man hath power on earth to forgive sins, (he saith to the sick of the palsy,) 11 I say unto thee, Arise, and take up thy bed, and go thy way into thine house. 12 And immediately he arose, took up the bed, and went forth before them all; insomuch that they were all amazed, and glorified God, saying, We never saw it on this fashion.”

The potential of covenant friendship that results in a “culture of bringing” is nowhere more beautifully illustrated than in the story of a paralyzed man whose friends had

enough compassion and faith to bring him before Jesus.

What a glorious example of covenant friendship. We could all use four friends like that, couldn't we?

Samuel Coleridge wrote a poem titled: "*Youth and Age*" and in it is a particular term, "*Friendship is a sheltering tree.*" That is a wonderful word picture. Friends are those whose lives are like branches:

- They provide shade...
- They provide refuge from the demanding, irritating and searing rays of the hot sun...
- You can find comfort when in close proximity to them...
- They bear fruit that provides nourishment and encouragement...

Isn't it interesting that when something occurs in your life and you are alone, you

pick up the phone and call a friend? (You use the lifeline of a friend)

Few things are lonelier than going through a sudden test or having something to celebrate and having no one to call.

(TALK ABOUT THIS MAN'S CONDITION – HAVE 4 PEOPLE BRING A PERSON IN ON A STRETCHER AND SET HIM ON THE STAGE)

(TALK ABOUT THIS ACTION OF GOING BEYOND THE PARAMETERS OF NORMAL FRIENDSHIP – THIS IS COVENANT FRIENDSHIP)

Covenant friendship requires...

COMPASSION

Somebody had to look upon this man's plight and have the heart to care! The King James Version says, "*He was sick of the palsy.*" One translation says he was a

“paralytic.” This word for *“palsy”* technically means that the muscles of the body are not working in harmony, making proper movement impossible. The *“palsy”* might also have included muscle tremors. This man was not likely lying in a simple, immobile state, it’s likely that his torment in not being able to move about was made worse by the discomfort of tremors.

Knowing his condition, I am quite sure he was SICK of the palsy! More importantly, he had four friends that were also SICK of the palsy! What are you SICK of that is going on in your:

- Family...
- Workplace...
- Friendships...

Everywhere we look there are people who are paralyzed by:

- Sin...
- Bondage...

- Oppression...
- Spiritual ignorance...
- Physical infirmity...
- Demonic possession...

Please notice, the Bible say's there were so many people in the house that no one else could enter so these guy's "***Tore the roof off...***" This action tells us that there was more than a friendship – There was true compassion! Their compassion disregarded:

- The personal property of the homeowner...
- The attitudes of those in the house...
- The cost of repairs...

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us a compassion that drives us to covenant with one another to BRING our acquaintances to church and a life group.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church! Are you ready? What are you going to do about it?

Covenant friendship requires...

FAITH

Hebrews 11:1 (CEV) “*Faith makes us sure of what we hope for and gives us proof of what we cannot see.*” It was not enough simply to feel sorry for the poor man who is SICK of the palsy! Somebody had to mix action with their compassion. It takes faith to BRING people to Jesus. Hebrews 11:6 (CEV) “*But without faith no one can please God. We must believe that God is real and that he rewards everyone who searches for him.*”

Jesus certainly saw action, but more than that He saw their faith. There was evidently a covenant of faith between these men and the guy who was SICK of the palsy!

I do not know if the man on the stretcher had faith. The Bible does not say. This I know, the men carrying the stretcher had faith!

Notice, each action they took screams faith:

- They contacted their sick friend...
- They acquired a stretcher...
- They convinced the man to go to see Jesus...
- They BROUGHT the man to see Jesus...
- They tore the roof off...
- They lowered him to the spot where Jesus was ministering...

Each action was an action of faith!

Who is in our circles of influence that needs a miracle from Jesus? Are we willing to take our friendship with them from a level of acquaintance to the level of a covenant relationship to see them helped?

If we can get our paralyzed friends into the presence of Jesus, then Jesus will do something about their situation!

Faith is a disposition of the mind that provokes action! Faith:

- Provokes prayer...
- Provokes giving...
- Provokes obedience...
- Provokes persistence...
- Provokes evangelism...
- Provokes action...

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us to a place of faith that drives us to covenant with one another to BRING our acquaintances to church and a life group.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church! Are you ready? What are you going to do about it?

A culture of invitation will often be met with...

RESISTANCE

Please know, when we step up to the plate and covenant to do our part to BRING people to church and a life group we will definitely meet with some resistance. There will be the resistance of:

- Inconvenience... They had to carry this man to Jesus. We must be willing to bear each other's burdens – even to bear each other! There was the inconvenience of the crowd. There were too many people pushing and shoving to get to Jesus. This meant they had to go up to the roof and literally break through the roof! They had to scrape or dig through the overlying covering of dried clay to remove roof tiles and lower the man in.
- Religious spirits... Jesus did not say to the man “*Rise and be healed...*” He said, “*Thy sins be forgiven thee...*” The

Scribes and religious leaders of the day questioned the authority of Jesus to forgive this man's sins. They reasoned in their hearts – they had a conversation within themselves – and considered Jesus a blasphemer. Religious spirits always question anyone who offers a challenge to the parameters of the past! Creating a culture of invitation flies in the face of “*Business as usual in the church.*”

Because the four friends were willing to push through the resistance they were able to get their friend to Jesus.

Are you as sick of the palsy as I am? I hope we are so sick of the palsy that it will stir in us action, to push past the resistance of creating a culture of invitation.

We must create a culture of BRINGING at CT Church! Are you ready? What are you going to do about it?

Covenant friendship results in...

REVELATION

These friends brought the man to Jesus for a physical healing. He received his healing but he got more than he, or they, bargained for! Ephesians 3:20 (NKJV) *“Now to Him who is able to do exceedingly abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that works in us.”*

The faith of these friends created a context for the Lord Jesus Christ to not only display His healing power but also His redemptive power! He not only got healed, he got saved! *“Thy sins be forgiven thee...”*

The miracle Jesus performed here went beyond a miracle of healing to a moment of revelation for:

- The man...
- The friends...
- The crowd...

As a result of all this, the text says that all who witnessed it were “*amazed...*” The Greek word translated “*amazed*” here means to remove something out of its place, to be out of one’s mind, or be transported beyond oneself with astonishment. In our modern way of saying it, the people were beside themselves!

The four friends gave God an opportunity to reveal who Jesus was, by BRINGING this man to Christ. It is time for us to create a culture of invitation and give God the chance to prove himself to our friends who are stricken with the palsy!

2017 must be the year we create a culture of invitation to our palsied friends to attend a life group and/or a church service. Are you ready? What are you going to do about it?

CONCLUSION:

These four friends had a covenant of faith with Jesus.

- Will you BRING others to Jesus in prayer?
- Will you BRING others to church?
- Will you BRING others to Life Groups?
- Will you BRING the testimony of Jesus' goodness in your mouth and share it with whomever you can?

(DISTRIBUTE CARDS FOR PEOPLE TO WRITE DOWN THE NAMES OF PEOPLE THEY ARE GOING TO TARGET TO INVITE BEFORE EASTER)

(ANNOUNCE INVITATION CARDS)

Turn to your neighbor and say:

(PLACE ON SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- I believe the scripture commands me to be a BRINGER...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...
- My pastor has asked me to become a BRINGER...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...
- I believe it is the will of God for me to be a BRINGER...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...
- The wellbeing of the Kingdom of God depends on me being a BRINGER...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...

- The growth of this church depends upon me becoming a BRINGER...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...
- I have a responsibility to you to bring someone to church and a life group...
- I commit to you that I will BRING people to church and a life group this year...

FACILITATORS QUESTIONS:

- 1) What was the physical problem with the man who needed a miracle? (*He was stricken with palsy*)
- 2) What did palsy look like as it manifested itself in the physical body of this man? (*He was paralyzed and experienced tremors – Much like a severe case of Parkinson's disease*)
- 3) How many people were involved in bringing the palsied man to Jesus? (*Four*)

- 4) What four things were required of these four men in order for their friend to receive a miracle? (*Compassion – Faith – Resistance – Revelation*)
- 5) How can we allow compassion to be extended through us to those in our circle of influence who are paralyzed by sin or their circumstances? (*Talk through how each person can develop an action plan of going after a person who is in need of what God can give them*)
- 6) How can we develop faith (Nerve) to become a bringer? (*Prayer – Develop a target list – Develop action items to show compassion – Gather the nerve (faith) to start the process*)
- 7) How can we prepare ourselves for the resistance we will meet? (*Pray – Have a made up mind to do this no matter what – Continue inviting and doing acts of compassion in spite of the resistance*)

- 8) What do we mean by “revelation” in this context? (*Revelation means that our friends who have been paralyzed by disease or circumstances of life have been brought into the presence of Jesus*)

COVENANT FINANCES

TEXT: Malachi 3:8-12 (NKJV) *"Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings. 9 You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation. 10 Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing that there will not be room enough to receive it. 11 "And I will rebuke the devourer for your sakes, So that he will not destroy the fruit of your ground, Nor shall the vine fail to bear fruit for you in the field," Says the LORD of hosts; 12 "And all nations will call*

you blessed, For you will be a delightful land," Says the LORD of hosts."

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) *"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed." 34 These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai."*

2 Corinthians 9:6-7 (NKJV) *"But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7 So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver."*

INTRO: Tithing is a subject that most ministers shy away from, simply because they know that the giving nerve is, with most people, a very sensitive nerve. Just because there are people in the church who are uncomfortable with the pastor talking openly about money does not release him from the responsibility of teaching on the subject! (My experience with a 47-year-old man who had attended church all of his life and was not a tither)

You can tell where a person's heart is by taking a quick look at their checkbook!
Jesus reiterated this in Matthew 6:21

(NKJV) ***“For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.”***

Someone asked Willie Sutton, the notorious bank robber, *“Why he robbed so many banks?”* He replied, *“That's where the money is.”* Each of us will leave a clear money trail to the location of our most valuable treasure!

Stewardship and tithing is all about a proper understanding of ownership; to whom do all our possessions belong? Psalm 24:1
(NKJV) ***“The earth is the LORD's, and all its fullness, The world and those who dwell therein.”*** Once we establish true ownership, stewardship becomes much easier. God is the owner of all our possessions! In the Bible, a steward was the business manager for a wealthy person. Remember Joseph, who was the steward (Business Manager) over the house of Potiphar?

The person who has developed a proper understanding of stewardship knows it is more of an attitude than an activity! 2
Corinthians 9:6-7 (NKJV) ***"But this I say: He who sows sparingly will also reap sparingly, and he who sows bountifully will also reap bountifully. 7 So let each one give as he purposes in his heart, not grudgingly or of necessity; for God loves a cheerful giver."***

Those of us who are operating in a true spirit of stewardship will continually ask ourselves the following question: *"What would God have us to do with what He has entrusted to us?"*

We can't give the tithe because it does not belong to us. If you loan me something, and I bring it back, I cannot take credit for giving that item to you because all I did was return it. The best we can do is return the

tithe to the Lord because it never belonged to us to begin with.

Am I thinking right to say, if it didn't belong to us and we refuse to return it, we stole it? (Give someone a \$20 bill before service and ask for it back right here)

THE COMMAND TO GIVE

Leviticus 27:30-34 (NLT) *"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to Him as holy. 31 If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent. 32 The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will*

be considered holy and cannot be redeemed.” 34 These are the commands that the LORD gave to the Israelites through Moses on Mount Sinai.” Malachi 3:10 (KJV) "Bring all the tithes into the storehouse..."

It would be literally impossible for a rational person to read these two Scriptures and conclude that tithing is anything other than a commandment! Tithing is not a suggestion for a Christian; it is a commandment to honor God with our finances. This commandment is not because He needs our money, it is because we need to give! It is not because the church needs our money, it is because we need to give!

We need to give the tenth part of our income to God because when we do we are acknowledging that ALL that we have belongs to God!

When a person is not a tither they tend to view their resources as belonging to them rather than to God.

We are stewards, God's business managers. Business managers carry out the plans of the proprietor of the business. Stewards are not required to be successful, they are required to be faithful! 1 Corinthians 4:2 (NKJV)

"Moreover it is required in stewards that one be found faithful."

Tithing fulfills a direct commandment of the Lord. We should tithe because we have been commanded to do so!

Can we agree to enter into covenant with God, this church and our fellow believers to be faithful in our giving in 2017?

GENEROSITY OR THEFT?

Malachi 3:8 (NKJV) ***"Will a man rob God? Yet you have robbed Me! But you say, 'In***

what way have we robbed You?' In tithes and offerings." I realize calling anyone who does not tithe a thief is pretty harsh and tends to upset some people. It only upsets people who are not tithers! (Story of Robert Hogan and the man that was upset about a special offering)

If you are not a tither I am not purposely attempting to call you names or upset you, I am not the author - I am the messenger! Because I am not the author I have no right to edit the contents of this book! (Sid Roth asked me about making some edits to my book)

God used His prophet to call these people thieves because they were. They were robbing Him of the first fruits and/or the tenth of all they acquired. These people were well versed in the law. They were very much aware of their financial responsibility

toward God and the temple; yet, they chose to not obey a clear directive from the Lord.

Leviticus 27 makes very clear several things:

- A tenth of all produce belonged to the Lord and was to be considered Holy! Vs. 30 ***"A tenth of the produce of the land, whether grain or fruit, belongs to the LORD and must be set apart to him as holy."***
- If the tithe were to be used for other things, when it was returned a twenty percent penalty was to be collected! Vs. 31 ***"If you want to redeem the LORD's tenth of the fruit or grain, you must pay its value, plus 20 percent."***
- Every tenth animal belonged to the Lord. They were to number the animals and give the tenth to the Lord. If it were to be discovered that they had substituted an animal for the tenth one, they were to give the tenth animal as well as the

substitute! Vs. 32-33 *"The LORD also owns every tenth animal counted off from your herds and flocks. They are set apart to him as holy. 33 The tenth animal must not be selected on the basis of whether it is good or bad, and no substitutions will be allowed. If any exchange is in fact made, then both the original animal and the substituted one will be considered holy and cannot be redeemed."*

- Tithing does not require faith and does not necessarily bring with it the blessing of multiplication. Tithing places the believer in a position of releasing the Lord to rebuke the devourer for the believer's sake.
- Tithing does not break the spirit of mammon on the money; the believer should bind the spirit of mammon over their income and pronounce the blessing of the Lord upon it.

- First fruit giving requires faith and enacts the blessing of multiplication upon our resources. One can tithe by giving one of ten, any one of ten, but giving the first-fruit requires giving the very first believing there will be nine more! First fruit giving requires faith and carries with it the thrill of high adventure with regard to our giving! (Bill Moore – Cow had triplets)

I become extremely amused at people who attempt to put up an argument concerning tithing based on the fact that the Old Testament has much more to say about tithing than does the New Testament. The same people still believe we should live by the Ten Commandments! This Scripture lets us know that Moses received this law concerning giving in exactly the same place and from the same source that he received the Ten Commandments! The law of tithing predates the Ten Commandments. Christ

fulfilled the sacrificial part of the law but did not do away with Old Testament principles!

Listen to the words of Jesus with regard to tithing, Matthew 23:23 (CEV) ***"You Pharisees and teachers are show-offs, and you're in for trouble! You give God a tenth of the spices from your garden, such as mint, dill, and cumin. Yet you neglect the more important matters of the Law, such as justice, mercy, and faithfulness. These are the important things you should have done, though you should not have left the others undone either."*** If you are one of those people who are hung up on tithing being an Old Testament principle, Jesus himself says here in the New Testament that the Pharisees should be paying their tithes.

Tithing was a righteous principle that predated the Law:

- Abraham gave a tenth to the Lord after victory over three kings in order to

honor and acknowledge the Lord as the source of that accomplishment. Genesis 18:20 (NKJV) ***“And blessed be God Most High, Who has delivered your enemies into your hand.” And he (Abraham) gave him a tithe of all.”***

- Jacob, the grandson of Abraham, promised that if God would keep him on his journey and bring him home to his family, that of everything he gained he would give the Lord a tithe. Genesis 28:20 (NKJV) ***Then Jacob made a vow, saying, “If God will be with me, and keep me in this way that I am going, and give me bread to eat and clothing to put on, so that I come back to my father’s house in peace, then the Lord shall be my God. And this stone which I have set as a pillar shall be God’s house, and of all that You give me I will surely give a tenth to You.”***

So you see, tithing came before the Law! It was a righteous principle that was incorporated into the Law. Therefore, if the Law had never been given the principle of tithing would still have been in effect!

I seriously doubt if there is anyone in this place that would take money out of the offering receptacle or be so bold as to hold a gun on the ushers! However, professing Christians do something far worse every week. They hold a gun to God's ribs by not returning the tithe!

Estee Lauder said, *"When a person with experience meets a person with money, the person with experience will get the money and the person with money will get experience."* (A deacon once told me that if I was *"Looking for experience they could furnish it."* He was right!)

When we withhold our tithe:

- We rob God...
- We rob our families...
- We rob our neighbor sitting down the pew from us...
- We rob the community in which the church is located...

Because of the thievery of some of God's people, the church will not have adequate resources to minister to its adherents or the world as it should.

Can we agree to enter into covenant with God, this church and our fellow believers to be faithful in our giving in 2017?

ACTIONS THAT LEAD TO A CURSE

Malachi 3:9 (NKJV) *"You are cursed with a curse, For you have robbed Me, Even this whole nation."*

The Miriam Webster dictionary defines a curse in the following way: *"To call upon*

divine or supernatural power to send injury upon."

There are people who will attempt to speak a curse over your life for the purpose of bringing what they think is bad luck.
(Witches across America were doing this recently against the Trump administration)

First of all, let me tell you that the enemy cannot curse what God has blessed.

However, as a Christian, we are capable of speaking curses over our own lives.

Proverbs 18:21 (NKJV) ***"Death and life are in the power of the tongue, And those who love it will eat its fruit."*** Proverbs 18:21

(CEV) ***"Words can bring death or life! Talk too much, and you will eat everything you say."*** Proverbs 18:21 (LB) ***"Those who love to talk will suffer the consequences. Men have died for saying the wrong thing!"***

I cannot pray long enough or passionately enough to break a self-inflicted curse over your life. About the time I get it broken, you will fail to tithe and you will be right back where you started. Then how is the curse broken? Surprisingly enough, not through prayer but through obedience!

Can we agree to enter into covenant with God, this church and our fellow believers to be faithful in our giving in 2017?

ACTIONS THAT LEAD TO BLESSING

Malachi 3:10 (KJV) *"Bring all the tithes into the storehouse, That there may be food in My house, And try Me now in this," Says the LORD of hosts, "If I will not open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it."*

The word blessing comes from the Hebrew word baraka (bear-aw-kah), and means:

- Source of blessing...
- Prosperity...
- Praise of God...
- A gift or present...
- A treaty of peace...

A closer look at this verse would reveal our tithing produces:

- A constant source of blessing – Who would refuse such a source of supply? Our faithfulness in tithing insures the source of divine blessing will be constantly flowing in our direction.
- Prosperity - Prosperity has been given a bad name by people who want to abuse it. Conversely, the intention of our Heavenly Father is to prosper everyone who has enough integrity and character to do what is right with their finances. Prosperity is having enough, plus a little!
- Praise of God - When we tithe faithfully, God is proud of us and even praises our

works! He brags on us. The end result of God bragging on us is that we will eventually hear it from His own lips, ***"Well done good and faithful servant..."***

- A gift or present - When we tithe we can get ready to receive gifts from the Lord! Not just at Christmas, on our birthday, or anniversary, but random acts of kindness when it is least expected! He will not be out-given!
- A treaty of peace - When we tithe, we enter into a treaty (Covenant) of peace! Peace in our life, home, work, church, and other relationships! Peace with God, His church and ourselves.

We should tithe because we want to enact these blessings on our lives and our families! In fact, His promise is, ***"I will open for you the windows of heaven And pour out for you such blessing That there will not be room enough to receive it."***

Can we agree to enter into covenant with God, this church and our fellow believers to be faithful in our giving in 2017?

CONCLUSION:

The great thing about tithing is that because it is based on ten percent of our income, God is not looking for equal giving; He is looking for equal sacrifice!

Let us covenant with one another before God today to be faithful tithers throughout 2017.

Turn to your brothers and sisters and say:
(PLACE ON THE SCREEN ONE AT A TIME)

- I admit to you that I believe tithing is commanded in God's Word...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful giver...

- I believe the Word of God teaches that anyone who does not tithe is stealing from God, their family, the church and the community...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful giver...
- I believe that when I tithe God springs into action and rebukes the devourer for my sake...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful giver...
- I believe that the first fruit carries with it the blessing of multiplication...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful giver...
- I believe God's Word pronounces many blessings upon those who tithe...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful...
- I believe I am required to do my part to bring provision to the work of God...
- I will be an obedient and cheerful giver...

FACILITATOR'S QUESTIONS:

- What is a tithe? *(10% of our total family income)*
- Who should tithe? *(All believers and all who want to be blessed)*
- Where should one tithe? *(To the church where you attend)*
- Should one tithe off the net or gross? *(Do you want a net blessing or a gross blessing?)*
- What does the Word say about those who choose not to tithe? *(They live under a self imposed curse)*
- What does the Word say about those who choose to tithe? *(They place themselves in the pathway of a blessing)*